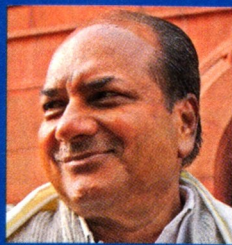
**PRANAB MUKHERJEE**

No secret that he is running the Government. Sonia relies on him to govern, but not to lead.

**P. CHIDAMBARAM**

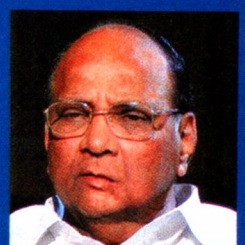
His no-nonsense image as home minister puts him ahead of the rest of the second rung.

**A.K. ANTONY**

The ultimate loyalist does not have the courage of conviction to be a serious contender.

**KAMAL NATH**

Effective but has not held a heavy-weight ministry. His ambitions exceed his credentials.

**SHARAD PAWAR**

After Manmohan's illness, made his intentions clear by rethinking decision not to contest polls.

with a cultural difference. Trust is relative and mutual suspicion coupled with absolute surrender to the dynastic deity is what holds the party together. Then there are the coalition leaders. Each one of them sees himself as a potential prime minister, at least in their inflated fantasies. The biggest question now is: will Manmohan still lead the UPA in the next elections? Will he be able to take the heat and dust of an Indian election and manage the ever demanding coalition partners? He has been a man of frugal habits. He spends over 10 hours a day on official work. A diabetic, he underwent his first bypass surgery when he was 58. Though his second surgery has been successful and his recovery much faster, will he be able to attend to a gruelling daily routine? As prime minister, he has to preside over 15 cabinet committees and groups of ministers, handle over 100 files a day, receive over 20 delegations and individuals and handle complex political issues. He also heads eight other ministries such as finance, information and broadcasting. According to insiders, his health took a beating for the worst soon after the vote of confidence during which he spoke to over 50 MPs personally. He has been devoting extra time in getting the nuclear deal confirmed and has been making frequent foreign visits.

Manmohan's Cabinet too is neither healthier nor younger. The average age of his ministers is about 67 years and eight of his ministers are over 70; 17

are over 60. Some of them have heart and other ailments. A few don't enjoy a clean image. For the past few months his Government has not been able to take any important decision except giving away economic packages which haven't yielded any result so far. The doctor who prescribed healthy economic reforms for 15 years suddenly found himself without a magic formula. Following his ill health, the visits of many foreign dignitaries have been cancelled. This at a time when the Indian government is seeking to mobilise world opinion and has launched a massive diplomatic offensive against Pakistan, lobbying for the extradition of terrorists. Since it is going to be one of the election issues, the prime minister will have to deal with many international leaders to take India's case forward. Normally a government takes voter-friendly decisions during the last few months of its tenure and forms several alliances. The prime minister will not be taking any such important decisions. The loss of six weeks of active work will not be easy to compensate.

■ ABILITY & AVAILABILITY

The prime minister, however, is in overdrive to prove that he is on the fast track to recovery. The PMO puts out daily health bulletins. And no sooner had the Cabinet condoled former president R. Venkataraman's death than the prime minister too posted a condolence message on his website. But if he takes full

charge, economic issues are not the only ones which he will have to handle. He has been declared as the prime ministerial candidate for the party, which requires him to travel all over the country seeking votes for his party and his performance. Though the Congress party has always been unsure about his ability to mobilise votes and has kept him away from gruelling election campaigns during the past five years, this time round they are seeking votes in his names only. He, the nuclear dealmaker, is the party's biggest achievement. With a question mark on his fitness, the Congress faces the risk of losing the advantage of having a leader and a slogan. The fear is not about his ability but his availability.

Even if he is asked to minimise his meetings, he will have to address at least 50 public rallies to garner support. Moreover, if the Congress is seeking votes in his name, he would be expected to contest a Lok Sabha election himself. He is the first prime minister to remain in office for five years without becoming a member of the Lok Sabha. Then, he has to deal with the difficult allies. So far, the division of responsibilities between the prime minister and the AICC president has been well defined. While Sonia dealt with political matters, he handled the Government. But during the past few months Sonia has not been very active as UPA leader and the allies have become used to dealing with Manmohan.

At a time when India needs a leader